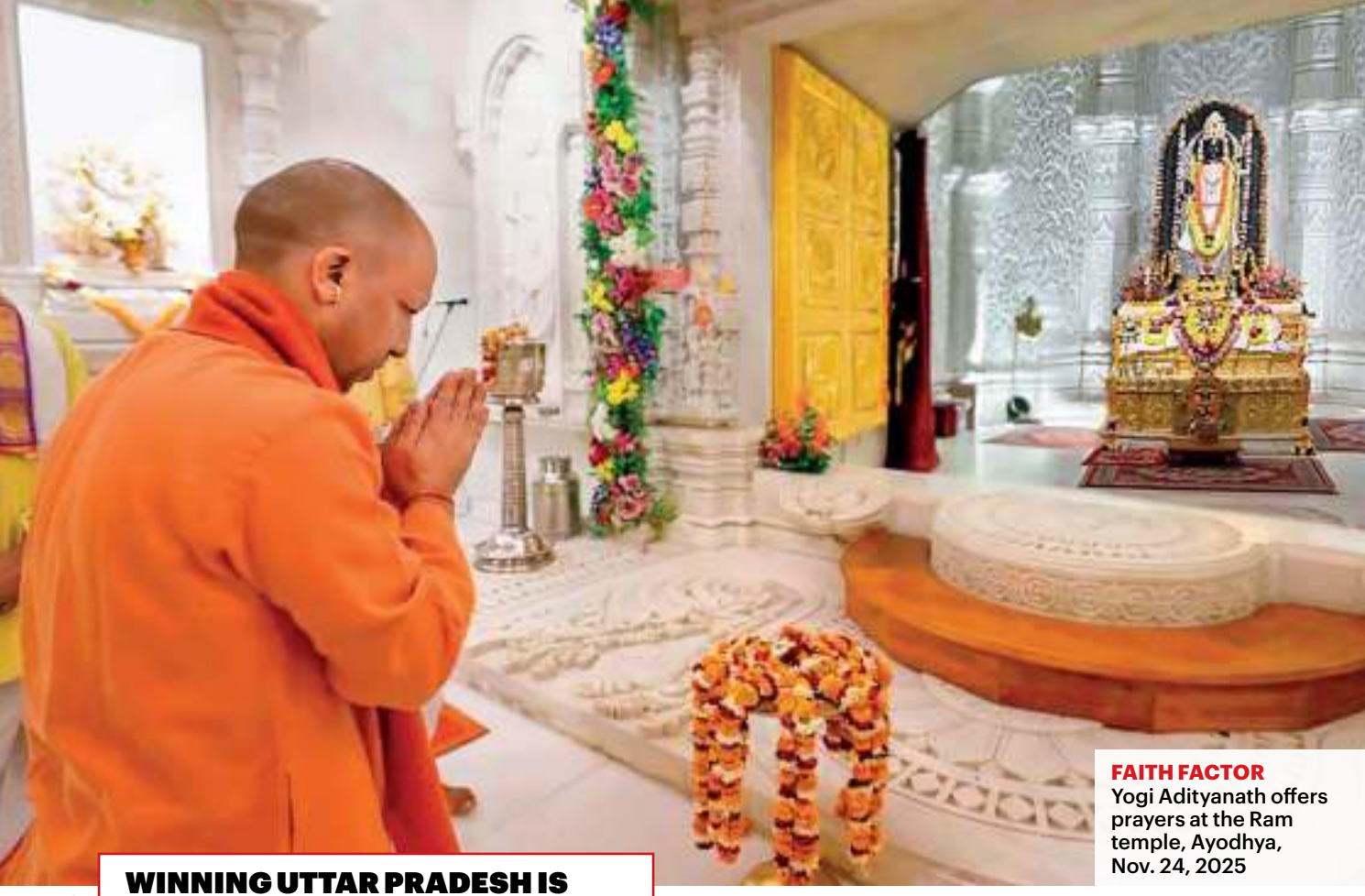


FAITH FACTOR
Yogi Adityanath offers prayers at the Ram temple, Ayodhya, Nov. 24, 2025

IANS

WINNING UTTAR PRADESH IS CRUCIAL FOR MODI AND BJP. BUT WHILE YOGI REMAINS POPULAR, ANTI-INCUMBENCY AND THE AYODHYA DONATION THEFT MAY MAKE IT AN UPHILL TASK

importance goes beyond numbers. A comfortable BJP victory in UP would steady the party's cadre across the country and reinforce the message that 2024 was merely a bad patch, not a political inflection point. A close contest, however, would send the opposite signal. The party knows exactly when the ground shifted. In the 2024 general election, the BJP won just 33 of UP's 80 LS seats, with a vote share of around 41 per cent—a sharp fall from the 62 seats it had secured in 2019 and its poorest performance in the state in the Modi era. The Samajwadi Party (SP) won 37 seats, while the INDIA bloc finished with 43. More damaging was the loss of Faizabad, the constituency that includes Ayodhya, just six months after the prime minister had inaugurated the Ram temple. That defeat demonstrated that the BJP could not rely on the temple to provide an enduring electoral advantage. The donation theft controversy this summer has complicated matters further by shifting the conversation from what was once its defining achievement to questions of mismanagement. The challenge now is to find an issue that can match the emotional resonance the Ram mandir once had in UP.

Some of what followed 2024 would have been difficult to imagine earlier. The party embraced a caste census, an idea many of its own leaders had spent years opposing. Sunil Bansal, the architect of the BJP's formidable booth machinery in the state, was moved to a national role. Yogi Adityanath was given greater latitude in senior bureaucratic appointments. There is little doubt within the BJP that Yogi remains the state's most effective vote-getter after Modi himself. But he also carries the burden of a decade in office—an incumbency no UP chief minister has successfully overcome before. And the past two months have tested precisely the section of the electorate that has traditionally backed him: aspirational, upper-caste, urban and young.

However, what worries BJP strategists in UP is not anti-incumbency or factionalism, it is arithmetic. In 2022, the BJP and its allies secured 43.8 per cent of the vote against 36.6 per cent for the SP alliance. But the margin alone does not explain the result. The Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) polled 12.9 per cent and converted little of it into seats. That stranded vote, concentrated in reserved constituencies and eastern UP, provided the BJP the cushion it needed to edge past a divided Opposition in a string of closely contested seats. That cushion is now shrinking. The BSP failed to win a single Lok Sabha seat in 2024, and its vote share slipped into single digits. Several of its district-level organisers and second-rung leaders—R.K. Chaudhary, now an MP with the SP, Indrajeet Saroj and Lalji Verma—have moved closer to SP chief Akhilesh Yadav. What they bring with them is not merely votes, but the organisational machinery that mobilises them: booth committees and local leaders who know which households in which lanes turn out on polling day.